Hoddle had said before the tournament that he was worried about my temperament in pressure situations. I'd not really had any trouble with him during the game until then but, just after half-time, he clattered into me from behind. Then, while I was down on the ground, he made as if to ruffle my hair. And gave it a tug. I flicked my leg up backwards towards him. It was instinctive, but the wrong thing to do. You just can't allow yourself to retaliate. I was provoked but, almost at the same moment I reacted, I knew I shouldn't have done. Of course, Simeone went down as if he'd been shot.

I've made a big mistake here. I'm going to be off. Gary Neville came up behind me, put his arm around my shoulder and then slapped me on the back.

'What have you done? Why did you do that?'

He wasn't having a go at me. Gary just wanted to know why I'd kicked out at Simeone. At that moment—and to this day—I don't know the answer to that. The referee, Kim Nielsen, didn't say a word to me. He just pulled the red card out of his pocket. I'll never forget the sight of it as long as I live. Look at the video now: Simeone acting like he's in intensive care; Veron telling the ref what he thought should happen; the ref with the card; Batistuta nodding, like he thought justice had been done; and me, just walking away, eyes already focused down the tunnel. It wasn't as if I was angry. The look on my face tells you: I was in a different world. Simeone had laid his trap and I'd jumped straight into it. Whatever else happens to me, those sixty seconds will always be with me.

Even before I got to the touchline, Terry Byrne had run over from the bench. He put an arm round my shoulder and walked down to the dressing room with me. As soon as we got there, I phoned Victoria in the States. Obviously I hadn't seen the replays on television and wanted to know what had happened. She was watching the game in a bar in New York. There was something not real about it she said. No-one could make sense of the fact that I'd been sent off. Why had it happened? There wasn't much more to say.

Terry stayed with me. I went in and had a shower. A long shower, like it was going to somehow wash all this away. Suddenly, Steve Slattery came running in and was shouting:

'We've scored! Sol's scored!'

I jumped out of the shower, but a moment later, he was back and telling us the goal had been disallowed. I put on my tracksuit and a French guy, a FIFA official, came and told me I had to go through to the drug-testing room. At